

Bronze Age China

The Shang dynasty flourished from c. 1600 to 1100 BCE and was the first society to produce cast bronze on a large scale. Believed to be semidivine, the ruling Shang kings performed rituals to please their ancestors and gods. The artifacts that they used reveal a sophisticated society.

BEFORE

In the Neolithic period (8000–1500 BCE), the Chinese began farming millet and rice, and keeping animals. This required a static population, so people began to build houses, and to live together in villages.

NEOLITHIC HEMUDU

In 1973, a Neolithic (late Stone Age) settlement dating from c. 5000 BCE was discovered at Hemudu, in southeast China. The finds included terra-cotta pottery, wooden and bone articles, and the remains of pigs and buffalo. There were also some whistles made from the bones of birds, possibly used to attract birds to snares. The most exciting discovery was **evidence that the people of Hemudu cultivated wet rice.**



YANGSHAO CLAY POT

YANGSHAO CULTURE

The area of Yangshao, in the eastern province of Henan, was first excavated in the 1920s, and yielded some significant finds. In the **village of Banpo**, which was occupied c. 4500–3750 BCE, the inhabitants cultivated millet, used polished stone hoes and knives, and **wore hemp and possibly silk.** Their village had a residential area with about 100 houses and other buildings. They produced pots made of red clay, some decorated with spiral patterns, and others with human or animal designs painted on them.

LONGSHAN CULTURE

Soon after the discoveries at Yangshao, a completely different type of Neolithic pottery was found at Longshan, in Shandong province. It was much finer than Yangshao ware, and was black, decorated with rings and grooves, and often elevated on a circular foot. Some of **the pots may have been turned on a wheel.** Longshan culture, which also produced polished stone axes, spread along the middle and lower Yangzi (the longest river in China). In time, it overtook Yangshao culture, which was already dying out.

BRONZE AGE ERLITOU

The Xia dynasty was long thought to be a mythological one, but in 1959, **palacelike buildings, tombs, and bronze artifacts** from c. 1900–1350 BCE were found at Erlitou, in Henan. The bronze objects found there are the **oldest yet found in China.** Their shapes suggest that they may have derived from Longshan pottery.

The Bronze Age (see p.43) in China produced two major achievements: a developed system of writing, and the discovery of bronze. The highly prized metal, which was produced on a huge scale, was cast for weapons, tools, and vessels used exclusively by the noble classes for religious rituals. Early Bronze Age civilization in China was a rigidly hierarchical society, ruled by a supremely powerful king and his nobles. The people of the Shang—the second of China’s ancient dynasties—believed that the king was invested with divine power from his ancestors, whose spirits were able to shape contemporary life if appeased with offerings. Bronze vessels were used for the sacrificial food and wine offered during these rituals, which can be seen as a precursor to the ceremonies of state used by later Chinese emperors (see pp.126–27). Much of what is known of Shang society has been gleaned from the study of the writings found on the “oracle bones” (see right).

The Shang state

In addition to support from aristocratic clans with whom they had family connections, Shang kings ruled their state with the assistance of officials. The Shang were frequently threatened by nomadic tribes from the inner Asian

steppes (a vast belt of grassland that stretches from Europe to China), and the state was kept on a war footing. Nobles performed military duties in return for land. Shang kings waged wars against their neighbors, thereby obtaining slave labor and loot. They established new settlements, and cultivated captured land for farming. Despite being a warlike society, Shang civilization was based on agriculture and hunting. The production of bronze, too, resulted in a relatively settled society, as a static community was required to mine and smelt the ores that contain copper and tin, the metals needed for bronze casting.

Shang capitals

The Shang ruled over much of northern China and the center of the country. The most important capitals were Zhengzhou, the capital in the earlier period of the dynasty, and Anyang, which was occupied c. 1300–1050 BCE. At Zhengzhou, a defensive city wall 4 miles (6.4 km) long enclosed a large settlement; the wall and the buildings within were constructed of stamped earth. The houses and workshops that have been excavated, and the variety of artifacts found inside them, indicate that Shang society was highly organized and rigidly ordered. Outside the capital of Anyang, at

A “taotie”—the head of a ferocious animal with horns and bulging eyes—is hidden within the labyrinth-like decoration.



Shang dynasty China

Key Bronze Age sites include the early capital city of Zhengzhou, which later moved to Anyang. Pre-Bronze Age finds have been made at the Paleolithic (c. 100,000–10,000 BCE) site of Zhoukoudian, and Neolithic (8000–1500 BCE) pottery has been discovered at Banpo and Hemudu.

KEY

- Palaeolithic site
- Neolithic site
- Bronze Age site
- Extent of Shang influence